R. Paul Fornia

www.paulfornia.com
www.linkedin.com/in/paulfornia/
paulfornia@gmail.com
(303) 859-9753

Machine Learning Engineer and Founder with over a decade in ML, AI, and Data Science, including deep scam and fraud detection expertise leading real-time Trust & Safety systems at Meta (WhatsApp, Facebook Marketplace) protecting billions of users, and building a scam-detection startup from scratch.

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Expertise — Python, SQL, Machine Learning, LLMs/Agentic AI, Data Science/Analysis, Trust & Safety
Professional Experience — PyTorch, TensorFlow, AWS, Git, Spark, R, PHP, Statistics
Classroom Experience — RL, AI Safety/Alignment, Computer Vision, Linear Algebra

WORK EXPERIENCE

BATLR.ai — Founder *2026 – Present*

- Built a real-time, AI-enabled scam detection API for P2P marketplaces and online communities. The B2B SaaS product included an LLM-based classifier with automated cost management and PII redaction, letting platforms add scam detection without an infrastructure overhaul
- Designed and ran a rigorous benchmark showing the classifier achieved 2x the scam recall of a naive AI baseline
- As solo founder, owned the full stack, product, market validation, pricing, and outreach, running day-to-day operations through an agentic AI workflow

Meta — Senior Software Engineer, Machine Learning *2021 – 2026*

WhatsApp Business Integrity team — scam detection and mitigation

- Led a cross-org emergency response, deploying system fixes that dramatically cut the prevalence of scam coming from Meta Verified accounts
- Negotiated and implemented WhatsApp Meta Verified process logic that reduced friction for good users, driving significant revenue gains with no measurable increase in scam
- Built an AI agent to support investigations into scam attacks from WhatsApp Business accounts, replacing or supplementing multi-day human SME review with instantaneous scam classifications for simple use cases

Facebook Marketplace Integrity anti-scam team

- Created spam folder triaging methods that stop hundreds of thousands of inauthentic messages per day, preventing millions of dollars of scam against users each month
- Implemented a novel technique for identifying scammers whose claimed and actual location don't match, used for multiple treatments across Meta
- Engineering lead (6 engineers, 10+ partners and stakeholders) for a short-term intensive sprint that blocked the vast majority of seller scammers in one country as a proof-of-concept; ideas expanded into other markets and full global launches
- Personal contributions and launches drove a measurable decrease in scam volume across Marketplace, on the order of tens of percent

Other Meta contributions

- Owned a large-scale feature (100M+ daily impressions) providing personalized recommendations of lesser-known Facebook Groups, growing the number of Groups with sustainable engagement by hundreds of thousands
- Supported Facebook's comment-writing assistant system, increasing system-wide coverage by 3%, resulting in millions of additional comments made daily

FINRA (Contractor via Tential) — Data Scientist *2020 – 2021*

- Developed and tested novel deep learning market surveillance models using TensorFlow/Keras
- Extracted model-ready datasets using PySpark, querying from petabytes of data (~100B records/day)

- Focused on deployment, preparing pipelines for a highly scaled production environment
- Built interactive visualizations to display model output for business users

TPC Energy Fund — Lead Data Scientist *2020*

- Provided accurate forecasts of returns and volatility of the wholesale power market using machine learning
- Optimized portfolios across thousands of trades using industry best practices
- Implemented robust backtesting systems to measure performance and risk
- Customized industry-standard solutions to fit nuanced financial situations

DataRobot — Customer Facing Data Scientist *2019 – 2020*

- Provided pro bono services to social impact organizations under the AI for Good Program
- Led five high-value accounts as primary data scientist
- Scoped and developed ML use cases for maximum ROI and impact
- Executed ML projects from framing to modeling to deployment
- Supported sales team by demoing DataRobot to executives and at trade shows
- Represented the AI for Good program externally in media interviews

Deloitte — Senior Consultant and Data Scientist *2014 – 2019*

- Developed machine learning, optimization, recommender, and UI solutions
- Led a team of four full-time consultants and data scientists
- Managed complex software development lifecycles
- Developed and led internal and external trainings in data science

Federal Reserve Board of Governors — Senior Research Assistant *2012 – 2014*

- Contributed research and analysis within the Financial Studies division's Research & Statistics section to support original policy and academic research
- Managed datasets, models, and visualizations

EDUCATION

Johns Hopkins University (2020) — MS, Computer Science

University of Colorado Boulder (2012) — BA, Economics (Magna Cum Laude); BS, Applied Mathematics (Computational Economics Emphasis)

AWARDS AND CERTIFICATIONS

Kaggle "Competitions Expert" — Highest rank 759th/180K globally

Jane Street Market Prediction ML Competition — Silver Medal, top 1% (2021)
Microsoft Indoor Navigation ML Competition — Silver Medal, top 3% (2021)

Amazon Web Services — Certified Cloud Practitioner (2018)

University of Washington (via Coursera) — Specialization in Machine Learning (2017)

Johns Hopkins University (via Coursera) — Specialization in Data Science (2015)

The George Washington University — Graduate Certificate in Financial Math (2014)

PUBLICATIONS

Cheong, S.A., **Fornia, R.P.,** Lee, G.H.T., Kok, J.L., Yim, W.S., Xu, D.Y. and Zhang, Y., 2012. The Japanese economy in crises: A time series segmentation study. *Economics*, 6(1).